Sita may be resigned to her future, but she also seems to accept it readily. She has already had her life upended several times. She was born in India's poor northeast, then moved as a young child with her family south to Chennai, then up to India's capital, New Delhi, and finally back to Chennai. The moves, while disruptive, were actually done in no small measure for her well-being. Her parents prefer India's south for their daughter's sake, she tells me, believing it to be safer for young women. To an outsider, Sita's parents' concern for their daughter seems hard to square with their insistence on picking her husband. What is clear, though, is that her parents refused to ignore the dangers facing women in India.

Allowing women to participate fully in Indian society begins with making it safer for them. Violence against women is endemic but supposedly more prevalent in the north. Such violence was brushed under the rug for decades, but the country was galvanized by the horrific December 2012 gang rape and murder of a twenty-three-year-old student on a bus in New Delhi.[1] Yet despite the public outcry, violence against women continues to occur far too often in India, and for reasons that are not simply criminal. Culture and religion play their role in the dangers that Indian women face, too, as in the 2010 murders of two young Muslim women who had eloped with Hindu men, what was determined to be an honor killing by their mothers in Uttar Pradesh, the northern state bordering Delhi.[2]

No one knows for sure the amount of violence perpetrated against women, or specific numbers regarding rape, much of which goes unreported. Yet even when charges are brought, only 26 percent of rape cases result in convictions in court.[3] In part in response to such numbers, India's first women's court opened in West Bengal in 2013. The court is headed by two female judges, and all the staff and government lawyers are women.[4] More broadly, Indian laws have begun to try to change society, if slowly. A 2013 bill prohibiting sexual harassment in the workplace was touted as a way to protect Indian women in the labor force, but according to the Federation of Indian Chambers of